

Extending AppFolio Max Into Custom Owner Reporting

A case study in portfolio earnings distributions and capital spending

White paper and case study

Property Ops Studio

Omer Futerman, Founder

propertyopsstudio.com

September 2026

Executive summary

Property owners can already receive financial statements, owner packets and transaction detail from AppFolio. The remaining problem is often more specific: the owner wants a concise answer that depends on several reports, a defined calculation and careful treatment of unusual transactions.

Property Ops Studio addressed that problem for a six-property portfolio. The completed system used AppFolio as the accounting source, scheduled data retrieval and validation through Power Automate, retained working data in SharePoint and produced a concise owner report. The report compared earnings with recorded distributions, preserved property-level negative results, showed recorded partner distributions and reconciled capital spending to the full portfolio total.

Privacy note: Property names, dates, dollar amounts, portfolio counts, record counts and other identifying details in this public paper have been changed. The calculations preserve the relationships demonstrated by the completed project but do not disclose the client's actual financial results.

For the reporting period ended June 30, 2026, the anonymized cash-basis example showed:

Owner reporting measure	Portfolio amount
Original net income	\$2,846,731.42
Approved property-specific escrow refund adjustment	\$318,764.29
Net income including the approved refund	\$3,165,495.71
Recorded distributions	\$2,071,983.66
Income including refund less recorded distributions	\$1,093,512.05
Capital expenditures explained in the report	\$1,693,284.17

The result was not a replacement for AppFolio reporting. It was a reusable reporting process built around an owner's question, with explicit rules for combining the source information and explaining exceptions.

The owner question

The project began with a practical question:

What did the portfolio earn, what had already been distributed, and where did the capital spending go?

No single total answered the whole question. A portfolio result could be positive while individual properties had distributed more than the defined earnings measure. Ownership percentages could describe an economic relationship without proving what each partner actually received. A capital expenditure total could be accurate while still giving the owner little understanding of the projects and vendors behind it.

The finished report therefore had to show both the consolidated portfolio and the underlying property results. It also had to distinguish recorded transactions from assumptions.

What the completed report provides

The approved report covers six properties on the same cash basis and reporting period. It brings the following information into one presentation:

- Original net income by property and for the portfolio
- One specifically approved escrow refund shown as a separate report adjustment
- Net income including that adjustment
- Actual recorded distributions, including partner detail where the source identified the recipient
- The difference between the defined earnings measure and recorded distributions
- Capital expenditures summarized by the six largest vendors, with all remaining spending grouped by category

Negative property results remain visible. In the anonymized example, three properties had distributions exceeding their respective income-including-adjustment figures even though the portfolio comparison remained positive. That distinction matters because a consolidated total can conceal different property-level conditions.

The capital expenditure section also reconciles to the complete \$1,693,284.17 anonymized portfolio total. The summary makes the largest expenditures readable without dropping the smaller transactions that make up the remainder.

How the accounting records worked together

The financial records were not competing versions of the same information. Each part of the accounting system answered a different question, and the owner report depended on connecting them correctly.

Accounting source	Question it answers	Use in the completed analysis
Profit and loss statement	What income and expenses were recognized during the period?	Established original cash-basis net income for each property and the portfolio
Balance sheet	What did the property own and owe at a specific date?	Provided context for cash, escrow, liabilities, loans and owner-equity accounts and distinguished operating results from transfers between balance-sheet accounts
General ledger	Which transactions produced the financial-statement balances?	Supplied the detailed evidence for distributions, capital expenditures, refunds, reversals, corrections, vendors and account classifications
Journal entries and capital accounts	What was actually recorded as an owner or partner distribution?	Identified recorded distributions without assuming that payments followed ownership percentages
Ownership records	Who currently owns each entity and at what percentage?	Supplied current owner names and percentages for presentation without treating them as proof of historical ownership on every transaction date
Vendor and bill records	Who received capital-expenditure payments and what were they for?	Supported the top-vendor presentation and classification of the remaining expenditures

Accounting source	Question it answers	Use in the completed analysis
Bank and cash records	What cash moved and what may be available now?	Supported cash research, while leaving current distributable cash to a separate liquidity analysis

Why the profit and loss statement did not tell the whole story

The profit and loss statement was the correct starting point. In the anonymized example, it established \$2,846,731.42 in original portfolio net income for the selected cash-basis period. It did not answer the complete owner question.

Owner distributions generally affect cash and equity accounts rather than income or expense accounts. A property can therefore report positive net income while having distributed more or less than that amount. The P&L shows earnings under the selected accounting basis; it does not provide the complete history of what each partner received.

The anonymized \$318,764.29 escrow refund also did not appear as income in the original P&L. It represented a movement from escrow into operating cash. The underlying ledger showed the transaction and its correction history, while the owner report presented the approved amount as a separate adjustment. Looking only at the P&L would have omitted that adjustment from the owner's defined comparison.

The P&L also could not explain the related reversal and replacement entries or identify the vendors and projects behind the full capital-expenditure total. Those questions required the transaction history in the general ledger and related records.

Finally, net income is not the same as cash available for distribution. A current distribution decision would also require reconciled bank balances, restricted cash, unpaid obligations, loan requirements, operating reserves and near-term spending needs. The anonymized \$1,093,512.05 shown in this paper is therefore a historical earnings-versus-distributions comparison, not a current liquidity determination.

What the balance sheet contributed

The balance sheet explains financial position at a date, while the P&L explains activity during a period. That distinction matters when money moves between cash, escrow, debt and owner-equity accounts without becoming ordinary income or expense.

An escrow refund can increase operating cash without becoming P&L income. An owner distribution can reduce cash and equity without becoming an expense. Loan principal can reduce both cash and debt while only the interest component affects the P&L. The balance sheet helps locate those effects and provides the starting point for evaluating liquidity.

The balance sheet alone still does not determine a safe distribution. Reported cash must be reconciled to the bank and evaluated against restrictions, liabilities, reserves and upcoming obligations.

How the historical data was researched

The historical analysis was built from transaction detail rather than by copying summary totals into a presentation.

- **Establish one reporting scope.** Use the same six properties, cash basis and July 1, 2025 through June 30, 2026 dates throughout the analysis.
- **Retrieve the ledger by property and period.** The anonymized example uses 83 property-month partitions and 218,764 general-ledger rows.

- **Validate coverage.** Confirm that each required property-month exists rather than treating a missing period as valid zero activity.
- **Reconcile earnings.** Check property-level calculations against the applicable AppFolio income statements before using the portfolio totals.
- **Research recorded distributions.** Use ledger, journal-entry and capital-account activity instead of estimating payments from ownership percentages.
- **Trace the refund history.** Review the original escrow refund with its reversal and replacement entries so the approved net amount is counted once.
- **Classify capital expenditures.** Connect spending to vendors and categories while retaining reconciliation to the complete total.
- **Document exceptions and preserve property results.** Keep the refund property specific and retain negative property-level differences in the consolidated report.

Why AppFolio's built in reports did not finish the analysis

AppFolio was the source of the accounting records, and its standard reports were necessary to the project. The income statement established net income. The balance sheet showed cash, escrow, liabilities and owner equity. The general ledger supplied the individual transactions behind those balances. Those reports answered important questions, but they did not combine themselves into the specific answer the owner requested.

What Report Builder can do

AppFolio Report Builder can start with a supported base report, add existing columns from other supported reports, filter the results and build certain comparisons across periods. This is useful when the desired answer already exists in AppFolio fields. For example, a user can add tenant information to a rent roll or compare an income statement across several periods.

AppFolio's current instructions describe selecting existing columns from a base report and several other supported reports. They also describe filters and comparative reporting. They do not describe a formula editor or a way for the user to create a new calculated field by adding and subtracting values drawn from different financial reports.

That limitation mattered here. The owner's requested result was not an existing AppFolio field. It required this calculation for every property and for the portfolio:

Original net income + the approved property-specific refund - actual recorded distributions = the historical earnings-versus-distributions difference.

Report Builder could display some of the source values, but it could not be configured to perform that new calculation. It also could not decide which ledger entries represented distributions, which costs qualified for the capital-expenditure presentation or why a reversed refund should be counted only once.

Combining reports also creates a practical risk. AppFolio explains that Report Builder matches records based on what the reports have in common. If the second report has several matching transactions, the base-report row can be repeated. A summarized income amount joined to many general-ledger transactions therefore needs careful review. A report can look complete while repeating an amount or producing blank columns where records did not match.

What someone would have to do in Excel

The report could be built in Excel, but it would not be a simple download followed by one formula. A person would first have to export or connect all of the required AppFolio reports. The income statement, balance sheet, general ledger, owner records, vendor information and other supporting schedules do not arrive as one ready-to-use table.

The person maintaining the workbook would have to:

- Make sure every export uses the same six properties, cash basis and reporting dates.
- Combine 83 property-month data partitions containing 218,764 general-ledger rows.
- Standardize property names, account numbers, dates, vendors and transaction descriptions so records from different reports can be matched.
- Build account-mapping tables that identify distributions, capital expenditures, transfers, contributions, reversals and other activity.
- Use Power Query, lookup formulas, conditional sums, pivot tables or the Excel Data Model to connect the reports.
- Add the approved refund to the correct property without changing AppFolio's books and without counting the reversed entry and replacement entry twice.
- Preserve negative property results instead of allowing a favorable portfolio total to hide them.
- Reconcile the workbook back to the AppFolio income statements and the complete capital-expenditure total.
- Protect formulas, lookup ranges and mapping tables from accidental changes.
- Extend every formula, query and pivot-table source when the next reporting period adds records, accounts or vendors.
- Review the workbook each period to confirm that a missing export, broken connection or unmatched name was not treated as zero activity.

AppFolio Excel Report Connection can reduce the work of refreshing supported saved reports. It does not create the owner's accounting method. The formulas, classifications, exception rules, validation and final presentation still have to be designed and maintained in Excel.

Excel also creates an operating risk when the workbook becomes the reporting system. Different employees may save separate copies, change a formula, refresh only part of the data or email a file to someone who should not retain it. Even when the workbook is correct, the company may become dependent on the one person who understands its queries, mappings and exceptions.

What Property Ops Studio did differently

Property Ops Studio used the AppFolio Max Database API to retrieve authorized source data without requiring an employee to repeat a long export process. It then built the reporting rules around the owner's question.

The work included identifying the correct source records, defining the accounting period and basis, mapping distribution and capital accounts, researching the refund history, preserving property-level results, validating that every expected property-month was present and reconciling the finished calculations to AppFolio.

Property Ops Studio also separated routine processing from accounting judgment. The system can repeat the approved steps, but it does not silently invent treatment for an unusual transaction. The refund remained a specifically approved report adjustment. It did not become a general rule for every escrow receipt, and it

did not change the accounting entries in AppFolio.

This approach provides practical benefits:

- Staff do not have to locate, export and combine the same reports every period.
- The same approved calculation is applied to every property.
- Missing data is identified instead of being silently treated as zero.
- Negative property results remain visible.
- Detailed capital spending is reduced to a readable owner presentation while still reconciling to the complete total.
- The organization is less dependent on one employee's private spreadsheet knowledge.
- The finished report can be reviewed, repeated and changed through a controlled process rather than by editing scattered workbook copies.

Security and privacy of the reporting records

The working reporting data and completed owner PDFs are retained in the client's Microsoft 365 SharePoint environment rather than in spreadsheets stored on individual computers or passed around as uncontrolled email attachments. Authorized users reach the report through the client's Microsoft 365 identity and SharePoint permissions.

Microsoft documents that SharePoint protects customer content with tenant isolation, role-based access controls and encryption in transit and at rest. SharePoint encrypts file content before storing the encrypted pieces in Microsoft Azure Storage. The project therefore benefits from the Microsoft 365 and Azure infrastructure underlying SharePoint, but it is not a separate client-managed Azure application or storage account.

Central storage does not guarantee that a cybersecurity incident can never occur. Security still depends on appropriate permissions, multifactor authentication, external-sharing controls, device protection and periodic access review. The benefit of the design is that it reduces uncontrolled financial-file copies and keeps the working data and published reports inside the client's centrally administered Microsoft 365 environment.

The property specific refund

In the anonymized example, one property had an insurance and tax escrow surplus refund of \$318,764.29. The original cash-basis income statement showed net income of negative \$64,218.77. The approved owner presentation added the refund separately, producing an income-including-refund measure of \$254,545.52 for that property.

The related ledger activity included reversal and replacement entries. The system did not add every visible credit. It retained the accounting record, applied the approved report treatment and counted the net refund once.

Property-specific calculation	Amount
Original net income	-\$64,218.77
Approved refund adjustment	+\$318,764.29
Income including the refund	\$254,545.52
Recorded distributions	-\$302,918.40
Income including refund less distributions	-\$48,372.88

This was a report-only adjustment. It did not change AppFolio's accounting records and does not establish a general rule for other escrow transactions or properties.

How the reporting system works

The operating design separates the accounting source, the reporting rules and the published document.

Component	Responsibility in the completed workflow
AppFolio Max	Supplies authorized property, ownership, general-ledger and related reporting data through the available interfaces
Power Automate	Retrieves data on a schedule, validates expected coverage, applies the approved workflow and generates the report
SharePoint	Retains the controlled reporting data, request records and published owner PDFs
Power Apps	Gives authorized staff a simple interface for choosing the report scope and opening the completed document
Property Ops Studio configuration	Defines the account mappings, calculations, exception treatment, presentation and operating controls

The production design uses scheduled cache updates so the report-generation path does not need to download a full year of ledger activity each time an owner asks for a report. In this public example, the anonymized cache contains 83 property-month partitions and 218,764 general-ledger rows. Unchanged periods can be reused, while validation prevents a missing period from being silently treated as zero.

The final approved report was generated from the retained data within several minutes and published to SharePoint as a concise PDF. Scheduled data-refresh, vendor-lookup and monthly-total processes were also verified through successful unattended runs.

Why the Max Database API mattered

The AppFolio Max Database API made the source information available for a controlled process outside an employee's spreadsheet session. It allowed the system to retrieve the authorized records on a schedule, retain the data needed for the report and validate whether the expected periods were present before calculating the result.

The API did not create the owner report on its own. It did not decide which accounts represented distributions, identify the meaning of the escrow refund, classify the capital spending or write the explanation presented to the owner. Those decisions and controls were the work performed by Property Ops Studio.

The difference is straightforward:

Using AppFolio reports and Excel	Using the Property Ops Studio workflow
An employee opens or refreshes several reports	Scheduled processes retrieve the approved source data
The employee combines exports and maintains formulas	The approved calculations are built into the repeatable workflow
The workbook owner remembers how unusual transactions were treated	The special treatment is documented and limited to the approved transaction
A missed export or broken formula may look like a valid zero	The workflow checks for expected property-period coverage
Workbook copies can be stored or emailed in different places	Working data and final PDFs remain in the controlled SharePoint environment
The owner package must be assembled after the analysis	The designed owner PDF is generated and published to SharePoint

AppFolio provided the accounting system and authorized data access. Property Ops Studio supplied the method that turned those records into the owner's answer.

The business value

The system gives the owner a shorter path from accounting records to a decision-ready explanation. It shows where the portfolio result came from, identifies properties where distributions exceeded the defined earnings measure and explains capital spending without requiring the owner to reconcile several exports.

It also reduces dependence on one employee who understands the entire workbook or reporting sequence. The organization retains a documented process that can be reviewed, repeated and adapted when a reporting rule changes.

For the management company, the same foundation can support additional owner questions, including renovation returns, debt outlook, rent performance and cross-system reporting. Each extension still requires defined source data, calculation rules and review responsibilities. The value comes from delivering a reliable answer, not from displaying more data.

Appropriate clients and limits

This approach is designed for cost-conscious midsize property operators that use or plan to use AppFolio Max, manage enough properties to justify repeatable reporting and do not maintain a dedicated internal integration team.

The completed report has important limits:

- The earnings-versus-distributions difference is a historical comparison. It does not determine cash currently available for distribution.
- Current ownership records do not by themselves prove historical ownership for every transaction date.
- A property-specific approved adjustment should not become a general rule for unrelated transactions.
- Source availability depends on the client's AppFolio plan, enabled interfaces, permissions and the fields exposed for the applicable records.

- Automated calculations do not replace accounting review, period close or approval of unusual items.

These limits make the report more useful because they identify what the numbers answer and what still requires a separate financial decision.

Property Ops Studio service model

Property Ops Studio operates as a specialist for property-management companies that need their business systems connected but cannot justify maintaining a dedicated integration and reporting department.

An owner-reporting engagement can include discovery, source mapping, report design, reconciliation rules, implementation, controlled testing, documentation and requested technical support. The scope should be defined through a fixed statement of work, with material changes handled through an approved change order. Pricing is quote based, subject to change and must be confirmed in the applicable proposal or statement of work.

The completed code is available to Property Ops Studio as a reusable foundation for future owner-reporting engagements. Reuse does not make a new deployment automatic: each client still requires authorized data access, source and account mapping, approved reporting rules, security configuration, testing and documentation.

Property Ops Studio does not replace the client's accountant, property manager or final approval process. It configures, adapts and supports the repeatable operating layer around the client's approved requirements.

Conclusion

The six-property anonymized example demonstrates how AppFolio data can support a more specific owner-reporting product. AppFolio remained the accounting source. SharePoint and Power Automate provided the controlled workflow. Property Ops Studio supplied the reporting logic that connected earnings, recorded distributions, the approved exception and capital spending in one concise document.

The finished system answered the owner's question without requiring the owner to assemble and maintain a complex spreadsheet. It also preserved the source distinctions that made the answer credible: actual payments rather than assumed allocations, a single documented refund rather than a broad adjustment policy, and property-level results rather than only a favorable portfolio total.

Sources

The reporting method and operating facts are based on the completed internal project and verified production records. Property names, partner names, dates, dollar amounts, portfolio counts, record counts and other identifying details have been changed for this public paper. The anonymized figures preserve the illustrated calculations but are not the client's actual financial results.

- [AppFolio Report Builder overview](#)
- [AppFolio Report Builder instructions and limitations](#)
- [AppFolio Excel Report Connection](#)
- [AppFolio Property Manager Max and Database API](#)
- [AppFolio Owner Portal reporting capabilities](#)
- [AppFolio discussion of tailored owner reporting](#)
- [Microsoft 365 SharePoint isolation and access controls](#)
- [Microsoft guidance on protecting SharePoint and OneDrive data](#)

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